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AI Data Centers: Broad Optimism Meets Local Hesitation

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4–5 minutes

It is widely understood that [artificial intelligence is advancing quickly](#). Less attention is often paid to the physical infrastructure needed to support that growth, including the data centres that power AI systems.

As governments and technology companies invest in new AI data centres across Canada, public opinion suggests Canadians are open to the idea, but not without reservations.

Our latest Leger survey finds that while many Canadians see AI data centres as a positive development, concerns about electricity demand, environmental impacts, and who should bear the costs remain front of mind.



Key Highlights

- Awareness of AI data centres is already well established, with 62% of Canadians saying they had heard about them before taking the survey.
- Canadians are more likely to view AI data centre development positively than negatively, with 46% calling it a good thing and 37% calling it a bad thing.
- Support becomes more divided at the provincial level, where 44% support development and 42% oppose it.
- Affordability and sustainability shape public opinion, with 81% concerned about higher household electricity bills and 79% concerned about environmental impacts.
- Canadians expect AI companies to take responsibility for the electricity and infrastructure their operations require.

Local Support Is Divided

Canadians generally recognize the potential value of investing in AI infrastructure. Nearly half, 46%, believe the development of AI data centres in Canada is a good thing. Positive perceptions are especially strong among Quebecers, men, and Canadians aged 55 and older.

Opinions become more divided when development is proposed within respondents' own province. Nationally, 44% support AI data centres in their province, while 42% oppose them.

This close split suggests that broad support for AI does not automatically translate into support for local projects. Electricity demand, infrastructure pressures, environmental effects, and community benefits are likely to influence how future developments are received.

Canadians Expect Companies To Help Cover The Costs

Affordability and sustainability are the most consistent concerns across the survey.

More than eight in ten Canadians, 81%, are concerned that AI data centres could increase household electricity bills. A similar proportion, 79%, are concerned about environmental impacts, including electricity use, water consumption, and greenhouse gas emissions.

Most Canadians are open to provincial governments or electricity providers supplying power to AI data centres, but many would attach conditions. Nearly one-third, 32%, believe companies should pay the full cost of their electricity use and any required infrastructure. Another 12% would only support access to

electricity from renewable or low-emission sources.

These findings point to a clear expectation that households and public systems should not carry a disproportionate share of the cost of AI expansion.

Looking Ahead

[As Canada expands its AI capabilities](#), public support appears to depend not only on innovation itself, but on how that innovation is implemented. Canadians are looking for growth that balances economic opportunity with affordability, environmental responsibility, and transparent investment decisions.

For governments, utilities, and technology companies, building trust may prove just as important as building the infrastructure.

Methodology

This study is based on an online survey of **1,505 Canadian residents aged 18 and older**, conducted from **July 10 to 13, 2026**, using Leger's [LEO online panel](#). Results were weighted according to age, gender, mother tongue, region, education, and presence of children in the household to ensure a representative sample of the Canadian population. A margin of error cannot be associated with a non-probability sample, but for comparison, a probability sample of this size would have a margin of error of **±2.53%**, 19 times out of 20.